

The Mirror Walker

This story was inspired by an audio piece and explores how sound can evoke images, memories, and stories across time.

The room was made of wood.

The walls were dark with age, and the air carried the faint smell of dust and rain. At the center of the room stood a mirror, its surface clouded by a thin layer of gray. A person stood before it, wiping the glass with a cloth.

Once.

Twice.

The reflection moved half a second too late.

The person stopped.

The room was silent.

Then the mirror began to ripple.

The wooden walls stretched as if they were being pulled from somewhere beyond the glass. The floor tilted beneath their feet. A sound rose from the mirror, low and distant, like a voice traveling through water.

Before they could step away, the reflection reached forward.

The person fell through.

They landed on stone.

When they opened their eyes, the wooden room was gone.

They were standing in another time.

The air was warm and heavy. Smoke drifted between buildings, carrying the smell of incense and burning wood. Somewhere beyond the walls, people were chanting. A drum answered them, deep and steady, its rhythm traveling through the ground.

The person looked down.

A digital camera was still in their hand.

They raised it instinctively and looked through the viewfinder.

The world changed.

For a moment, the ancient streets became fragments of photographs. Faces froze. Smoke became a white blur. The movement of people seemed to disappear between frames.

Then the drum sounded again.

Everything moved.

The person followed the sound.

They walked through unfamiliar streets, past rituals they could not understand, carrying a camera from a world that did not yet exist. The farther they went, the less certain they became of which time they belonged to.

Then, without warning, a train whistle cut through the chanting.

The sound was sharp enough to split the world in two.

The ancient buildings disappeared.

Steam surrounded them.

Metal wheels screamed against iron tracks. Machinery shook the ground. Somewhere nearby, a train began to move, its black silhouette disappearing into a cloud of smoke.

The person stood beside the tracks, still holding the camera.

The drumbeat had not disappeared.

It had changed.

Its rhythm lived inside the machinery now, buried beneath the clatter of wheels and the hiss of steam. The past had not ended. It had simply become something else.

They followed the train.

Years passed in moments.

Stone became steel.

Fire became electricity.

The world grew louder.

And then, just as suddenly as they had arrived, the person was home.

They stood in front of a familiar door.

Everything looked exactly as it should.

The same walls.

The same floor.

The same quiet room.

They reached for the handle.

Behind the door came a sound they recognized, but something about it was wrong. It stretched and distorted, as though the sound were being played from a broken machine. A melody became noise. A familiar voice became a distant echo.

They opened the door.

Nothing was there.

Only darkness.

The person stepped backward.

The mirror was behind them.

Its surface was no longer reflective.

Instead, it showed every place they had seen.

The ancient streets.

The chanting.

The train.

The smoke.

The wooden room.

All of them existed at once.

The person touched the glass.

A crack appeared.

Then another.

The mirror shattered.

Silence.

The person opened their eyes.

They were standing in the wooden room again.

The mirror was whole.

The cloth was still in their hand.

For a moment, they could not move.

Had they traveled through time?

Had they fallen into the mirror?

Or had they simply been standing there all along?

They looked down.

The digital camera was gone.

Only the cloth remained.

They slowly turned toward the mirror.

Their reflection stared back.

This time, it moved at exactly the same moment.

The person began wiping the glass again.

Once.

Twice.

And somewhere, very far away, a drum began to play.